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MBA Admissions Checklist

Step-by-Step Roadmap to Secure Admits at Top Global Business Schools

13	11	Print
SECTIONS	EXERCISES	WITH SPACE TO WRITE

How to use this guide: print it, work through it in order, and write in the spaces. Every exercise has room for your answers, and you can print extra copies of any page.

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From **RoleEdge**, founded by Mayank Kapoor, former Manager at Bain & Company and Warwick MBA. Free to use and share.

Why an MBA Admissions Checklist Is Essential

Applying for an MBA at top schools (Harvard, Wharton, INSEAD, LBS, ISB) is like running a marathon—you need structure, stamina, and a plan. Many strong candidates fail not because they lack potential but because they mismanage **deadlines, storytelling, or fit.**

An admissions checklist ensures you approach this strategically, not reactively. Each step—resume, essays, recommendations—must align to tell a **coherent narrative.**

REFLECTION

Write why you want an MBA in 1–2 sentences. Career pivot? Faster leadership growth? Global exposure?

STEP 1

Clarify Your MBA Goals (Short & Long Term)

Admissions committees don't want "general ambition." They want **clarity.**

- **Short-Term Goal (2–3 years post-MBA):** Consulting at Bain, Finance at JP Morgan, Product at Amazon.
- **Long-Term Goal (10+ years):** Partner, CFO, Entrepreneur, Policy Leader.

EXERCISE

Write one short-term and one long-term goal in 2 lines each.

My goal	
Short term (2–3 years after the MBA)	
Long term (10+ years)	

STEP 2

Select the Right Schools – Dream, Target, Safety

Use the **DTS framework**:

- Dream: Harvard, Stanford, INSEAD.
- Target: Duke Fuqua, LBS, ISB.
- Safety: Tier-2 programs that still match goals.

EXERCISE

List 2–3 schools in each DTS bucket.

Dream	Target	Safety

STEP 3

Research Program Strengths & Fit

Schools differ in culture, strengths, and networks. Example:

- INSEAD = international diversity + consulting placements.
- Wharton = finance powerhouse.
- LBS = London exposure + global mobility.
- ISB = India focus + global faculty.

EXERCISE

Pick 1 school. Write 2 strengths and how they align with your goals.

School strength	How it fits my goals

STEP 4

Build a Competitive Resume for Admissions

Your admissions resume should highlight:

- Leadership: Did you lead teams/projects?
- Impact: Did you save costs, increase revenue, influence strategy?
- Extracurriculars: Volunteer, sports, NGOs.

Don't recycle job CVs—they're too task-heavy.

Focus on leadership potential and quantifiable achievements.

EXERCISE

Rewrite 1 resume bullet with numbers + leadership focus.

STEP 5

Crafting Authentic Essays & Personal Statements

Essays = your **voice.** They must:

- Answer why MBA, why now, why this school.
- Showcase personal values & resilience.
- Tell unique stories—not clichés.

EXAMPLE

Instead of "I want to lead," show: "During a crisis project, I aligned 5 teams across geographies to deliver under budget."

EXERCISE

Draft 3 bullet points from your life you could expand into essay stories.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

STEP 6

Choosing and Guiding Recommenders

Your recommender should be:

- Someone who **knows you well.**
- Can speak about leadership & growth.
- Aligned with your essays (no contradictions).

Provide them a **recommendation packet**: your resume, essays, and 3 key stories they can highlight.

EXERCISE

Write 2 names of potential recommenders.

Recommender	How they know me	Stories they can tell

STEP 7

Preparing for GMAT/GRE & Language Tests

- **GMAT/GRE:** Aim at or above the median score in each target school's latest class profile.
- **IELTS/TOEFL:** Needed if undergrad wasn't in English.
- Prep tip: Practice 1 hr/day for 6–9 months.

EXERCISE

Write your target score + exam date.

Test	Target score	Exam date
GMAT / GRE		
IELTS / TOEFL (if needed)		

STEP 8

Structuring Your Application Timeline

MBA apps = project management.

- Round 1: September–October (often the best scholarship chances).
- Round 2: January–February (a larger applicant pool).
- Round 3: riskier; use it only for backup schools.

WORKSHEET

Build a calendar with GMAT prep, essay drafts, and submission deadlines.

Month	Test prep	Essays and recommenders	Deadlines

STEP 9

Preparing for MBA Interviews

MBA interviews test **fit + communication.**

- Common Qs: “Why MBA?” “Why this school?” “Leadership story?”
- Practice with **mock interviews.**

EXERCISE

Record a 2-min answer to “Why MBA now?” and review for clarity.

STEP 10

Planning Scholarships, Loans & Funding

Funding is often overlooked. Options:

- Merit scholarships (ISB, Oxford).
- Need-based aid (Harvard, Stanford).
- Loans: Prodigy Finance, MPower, Indian banks.

EXERCISE

List 2 funding sources you’d explore.

1.
2.

EXAMPLE

Worked examples

An illustrative example. Names and details are representative, not real clients.

An Indian business school admit: Aarav, a chartered accountant at a Big Four firm, wrote essays about leading through client crises. Result: an admit with a 30% scholarship.

A European business school admit: Maria, a consultant, highlighted her international mobility and growth mindset. Result: an admit with a scholarship.

> LESSON
>
> Storytelling + clarity + funding prep = success.

Common Pitfalls and Your 90-Day Plan

Mistakes: Generic essays, weak recommenders, late submissions.

Fix: Start early, build strong stories, align every element.

Your 90-day plan

When	Focus	My actions
Days 1–30	School research + resume rewrite.	
Days 31–60	Essays + recommendations.	
Days 61–90	Interview prep + funding strategy.	

My notes

NEXT STEP

Want someone to check your work?

Bring this guide to a free call with RoleEdge. We'll go through your answers and help you plan what comes next.

Book a free call at roleedge.com/book